



AIR-DRYING

Herbs, such as mint, are best air-dried indoors as this will help them retain their flavor and color. A warm, dry spot is ideal for this.

DRYING AND STORING

If using foraged ingredients, wash them immediately under cold running water, then lightly pat them dry with a paper towel. Lay out the plants or herbs on a baking sheet, or place them in a basket and leave them to dry, covered with a light cloth or clean dish towel, in a warm, dry place. This may take several days, depending on the level of humidity. You can also dry them in an oven on very low heat or in a dehydrator. Do not dry them in a microwave oven as it may cause scorching, and the rapid heating could damage some of the aromatic oils in the plants.

To store herbs—whether picked and dried or store-bought—keep them in an airtight container made of glass, ceramics, or stainless steel, away from heat and other competing odors.

DRIED INGREDIENTS HAVE CONCENTRATED OILS THAT RELEASE THEIR GOODNESS IN HOT WATER

PREPARING INGREDIENTS

Fruits are best used fresh in tisanes. While plants may be used fresh, they will not be as potent in taste or aroma as when dried. This is because drying concentrates the oils and other components, which are released more easily when they are reconstituted in hot water. If infusing fresh herbs, use three times as much as dry.

To prepare your tisane, break the dried herbs into smaller pieces and measure 1 teaspoon of each herb per cup. Tisanes should be infused with freshly boiled water and steeped for approximately 5 minutes. Unlike tea, tisanes do not require different timings per type. As herbs are not oxidized, or processed in any way apart from drying, they do not require delicate treatment.

DECOCTIONS

Roots and stems need to be boiled in water to release their flavors and nutrients, a process known as “decoction.” Boil the ingredients for 5–10 minutes, then strain and cool the liquid before drinking.

Use only stainless steel or glass pots to boil herbs. Do not use aluminium, iron, or copper cookware, as the chemical composition will affect the essence and integrity of the ingredients.